INTRODUCTION

The economic reforms initiated in 1991 is now into the 22nd year. In this period there was hardly a day that some news, news analysis, write up or article did not appear in the newspapers. Several highly acclaimed books have been authored on India's economic reforms by some of the best experts of economics from India and abroad. Still students, especially coming from non-economics background, are generally at a loss on the 'pros' and 'cons' of the reform process.

ECONOMIC REFORMS

Popularly, economic reforms denote the process in which a government prescribes declining role for state and expanding role for the private sector in an economy. So let's unravel the reform process based on the author's classroom interaction with students. It is safer to see economic reform as a policy shift in an economy from one to another or ***'alternative development strategies'.*** Economists attribute the differences in the performance of economies to the differences in the 'strategies' they follow. The different strategies of development evolved through a long period of trial and error by the different countries under the influence of different sets of ideologies. But the process has been like an educational trip. To understand the term 'economic reform' and more so to clarify the confusion concerning it in the Indian context, we must see the different 'alternative development strategies' which evolved through time. A brief description is given below:

1. Planning Model

Till the rise of the Soviet Union, the prevalent development strategy in the Euro-American countries was the capitalist system of economy which promoted the principles of the laissez-faire and dominant role for the private capital in the economy. Once the Soviet Union went for the planning model (including the East European countries and finally China in 1949) most of the developing countries after their independence were influenced